

High-chance portions - geo-india

Combined original study articles for this topic's highest-probability PYQ themes.

Indian Physiography & Drainage

~80% · Himalayan ranges · Peninsular plateaus · Drainage patterns · Passes · Coastal plains

Why this portion (PYQ lens)

Portion chance ~80%. Steady; parent geo-india ~77%.

Years appeared (synthesis): 2016, 2017, 2018, 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024, 2025

Why UPSC asks this

Region - feature matching is the backbone of India physical geography Prelims.

Syllabus framing

Portion chance ~80%. Steady; parent geo-india ~77%. This portion sits inside geo-india and centres on Indian physiography and drainage. Region - feature matching is the backbone of India physical geography Prelims.

Recurring PYQ angles: Himalayan ranges, Peninsular plateaus, Drainage patterns, Passes, Coastal plains. Approximate appearance years in the 2016-2025 educational synthesis: 2016, 2017, 2018, 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024, 2025. Use the chance percentage only to sequence study hours - it is not an official prediction.

Core map of Indian physiography and drainage

Himalayan divisions: Trans/Greater/Lesser/Siwalik longitudinal zonation. Syntaxial bends: NW and NE bends - map awareness.

Passes: Strategic/historical - select list not encyclopedia. Indo-Gangetic plain: Alluvial fertility and flood regimes.

Hold this core map as your elimination spine before memorising peripheral CA overlays.

Core concepts and definitions

Peninsular plateau: Old hard rock; Deccan traps; residual hills. Western vs Eastern Ghats: Continuity, elevation, rainfall contrasts.

Coastal plains: West narrower; east wider deltas narrative. Himalayan drainage: Antecedent/tectonic influences; snow-fed.

Institutions, processes and mechanisms

Peninsular drainage: Rain-fed; gentle gradients; east-flowing majors. West-flowing exceptions: Narmada/Tapi rift valleys - classic.

Ganga - Brahmaputra - Indus: System personalities. Godavari/Krishna/Kaveri/Mahanadi: Peninsular east-flowing set.

India angle and applied examples

Drainage patterns: Dendritic/trellis/radial - rock structure links. Water divides: Western Ghats divide idea.

Lakes: Wular, Chilika, Pulicat, Sambhar - type discrimination. Islands: Andaman-Nicobar tectonic; Lakshadweep coral.

Comparisons, linkages and discriminators

Thar desert edge: Physiographic transition. Doab concept: Land between rivers.

River interlinking debates: Conceptual - not scheme spam. Floodplains/khadar/bhangar: Alluvial terms.

India angle

Map practice weekly beats prose-only reading for this portion.

Question patterns and exam spine

Matching lists and statements on Indian physiography and drainage.

Revision spine: Definitions -> table -> India -> traps.

Eliminate anachronisms and category errors first, then test remaining options against table rows and must-remember triggers.

Trap watch-list (specific)

Avoid: All Himalayan rivers purely rain-fed. Avoid: Narmada east-flowing. Avoid: Eastern Ghats as continuous as Western. Avoid: Chilika as freshwater always.

Drainage contrast

Type | Cue

Himalayan rivers -- Snow+rain; long

Peninsular -- Rain-fed; graded

West-flowing -- Narmada/Tapi rifts

East-flowing majors -- Deltaic mouths

Map / list facts

- Major passes select
- Narmada rift
- Delta coasts
- Andaman vs Lakshadweep

Common traps

- x All Himalayan rivers purely rain-fed
- x Narmada east-flowing
- x Eastern Ghats as continuous as Western
- x Chilika as freshwater always

Must remember

- Himalayan zones
- W vs E Ghats
- Narmada/Tapi west
- Ganga system
- Dendritic etc.
- Island types

Quick revision checklist

- ☐ Reproduce table
- ☐ 5 must-remembers
- ☐ 3 traps
- ☐ India anchor
- ☐ 10 MCQs

Educational prioritisation heuristic - not an official UPSC prediction. (c) UPSC IAS Study Hub original notes.

Agriculture, Resources & Minerals

~70% · Crops · Soils · Mineral belts · Energy resources · Irrigation

Why this portion (PYQ lens)

Portion chance ~70%. Location matching; parent geo-india ~77%.

Years appeared (synthesis): 2016, 2017, 2018, 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024, 2025

Why UPSC asks this

Crop - state and mineral - belt pairs are high-yield if drilled as tables.

Syllabus framing

Portion chance ~70%. Location matching; parent geo-india ~77%. This portion sits inside geo-india and centres on Indian agriculture, soils and mineral resources. Crop - state and mineral - belt pairs are high-yield if drilled as tables.

Recurring PYQ angles: Crops, Soils, Mineral belts, Energy resources, Irrigation. Approximate appearance years in the 2016-2025 educational synthesis: 2016, 2017, 2018, 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024, 2025. Use the chance percentage only to sequence study hours - it is not an official prediction.

Core map of Indian agriculture, soils and mineral resources

Black soils: Regur; cotton; Deccan traps link. Alluvial soils: Northern plains; intensive agriculture.

Red/laterite: Peninsular distributions; leaching. Rice/wheat geography: Rainfall/irrigation contrasts.

Hold this core map as your elimination spine before memorising peripheral CA overlays.

Core concepts and definitions

Millets revival: Nutrition + dryland - CA - static. Sugarcane/cotton/jute: Locational factors.

Plantation crops: South/NE niches. Green Revolution regions: Punjab-Haryana-West UP narrative + limits.

Institutions, processes and mechanisms

Irrigation types: Canal/well/tank regional patterns. Iron ore belts: Odisha-Jharkhand-Chhattisgarh etc.

Bauxite/manganese/copper: Select belts. Coalfields: Gondwana vs tertiary - Damodar etc.

India angle and applied examples

Petroleum/gas basins: Mumbai High, KG, Assam narrative. Critical minerals CA: Lithium/rare earth awareness.

Forest types link: Resource geography overlap. Fisheries: Coastal and inland.

Comparisons, linkages and discriminators

Horticulture belts: Select examples. Soil degradation: Salinity/erosion statements.

Agro-climatic regions: Planning idea. Mineral policy CA: Light overlay only.

India angle

One mineral map + one crop map handwritten > 50 pages unread.

Question patterns and exam spine

Matching lists and statements on Indian agriculture, soils and mineral resources.

Revision spine: Definitions -> table -> India -> traps.

Eliminate anachronisms and category errors first, then test remaining options against table rows and must-remember triggers.

Trap watch-list (specific)

Avoid: Black soil only in north India. Avoid: All coal in one state. Avoid: Millets need high water always. Avoid: Confusing bauxite and iron belts.

Soil - crop cues

Soil | Cue crop/region

Black/regur -- Cotton/Deccan

Alluvial -- Rice-wheat plains

Laterite -- Leached uplands

Arid -- Rajasthan margins

Map / list facts

- Damodar coal
- Odisha iron
- Mumbai High
- Cotton Deccan

Common traps

- x Black soil only in north India
- x All coal in one state
- x Millets need high water always
- x Confusing bauxite and iron belts

Must remember

- Black soil - cotton - Deccan
- Alluvial plains
- Major iron/coal belts
- Mumbai High
- Irrigation regionality

Quick revision checklist

- [] Reproduce table
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